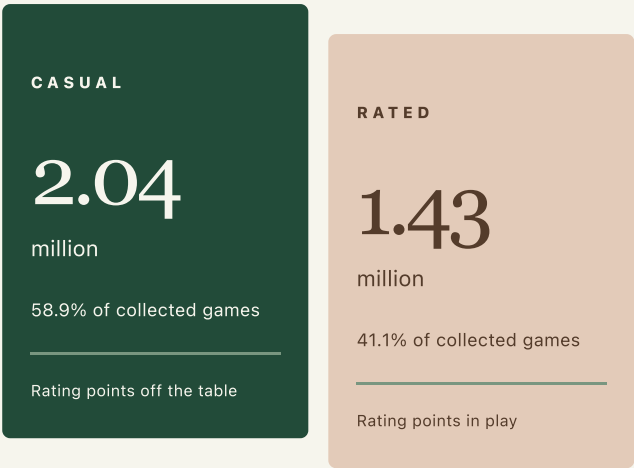


Same Maia. *Two ways to play.*

When rating points are off the table, what changes? A look at shared habits, quick returns and results across **3.47 million** collected games.

Companion to [One more game with Maia](#). Same three bots, same three-year last-move window. All-time profile totals are a separate snapshot.



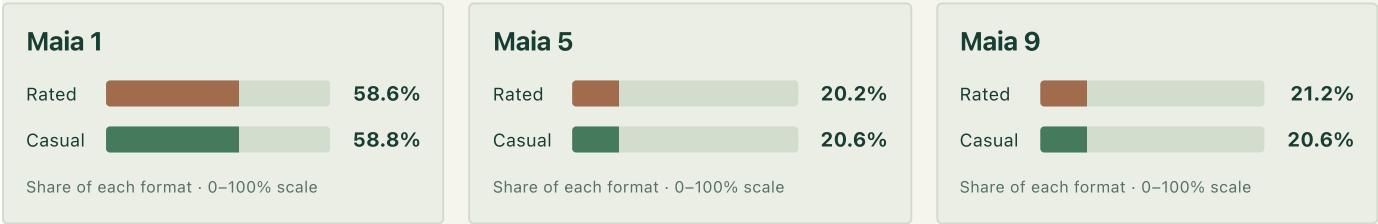
● **One important difference:** 118,056 casual games (5.8%) are tagged fromPosition. All rated games are tagged standard. We separate these when comparing results and repeat play; exact starting positions were not saved.

01 / WHAT STAYS FAMILIAR

The favorites barely change.

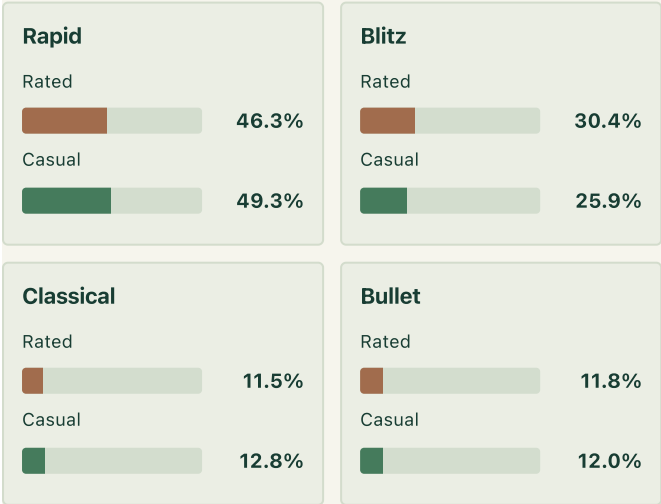
Maia 1 attracts almost the same share in each format: **58.8% casual** and **58.6% rated**. And 10+0 is the most popular exact clock in both.

Rated Casual



A little more slow chess in casual.

Rapid and classical together account for 62.0% of casual games, versus 57.8% of rated games. Those are game-weighted shares, so very active accounts matter.



The same top three clocks.

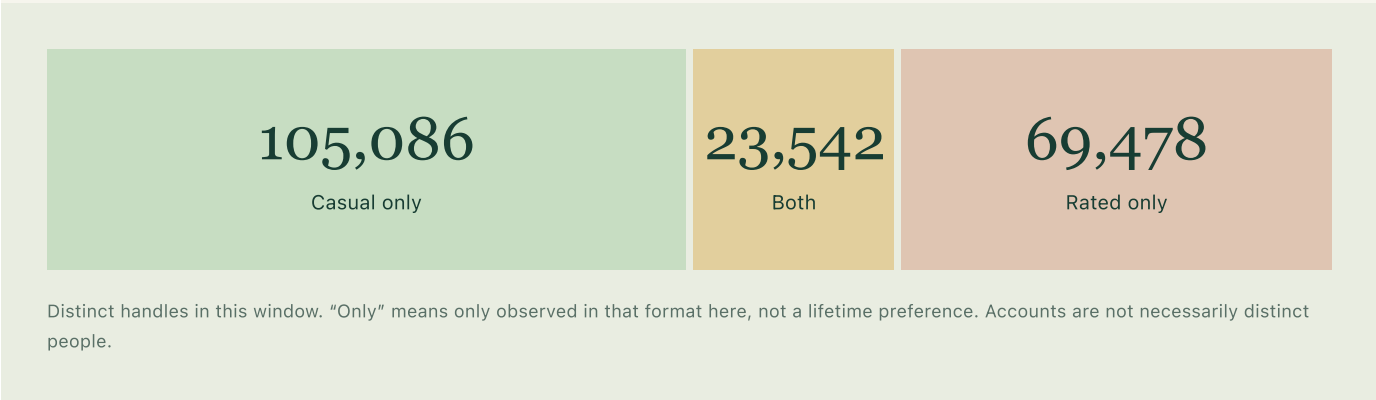
Rank	Rated clock	Rated share	Casual clock	Casual share
1	10+0	15.1%	10+0	16.7%
2	5+3	10.0%	5+3	9.3%
3	10+5	6.1%	10+5	6.8%
4	3+2	4.8%	1+0	6.3%
5	15+10	4.7%	15+10	5.8%

Starting minutes + increment seconds. These preference comparisons include all collected games, including custom-start records. Share denominators are all games in each format.

Watch the 1+0 ranking. One account contributes 63,504 casual 1+0 games in September alone. That is 49.2% of casual 1+0 games in the whole collection. Remove that account's games and 1+0 falls from fourth to seventh; casual bullet's share falls from 12.0% to 9.2%.

A bigger casual audience. A familiar pattern of regulars.

We see 128,628 casual accounts and 93,020 rated accounts. Only **11.9% of the 198,106 distinct observed handles** appear in both formats.



Many visitors. A very active core.

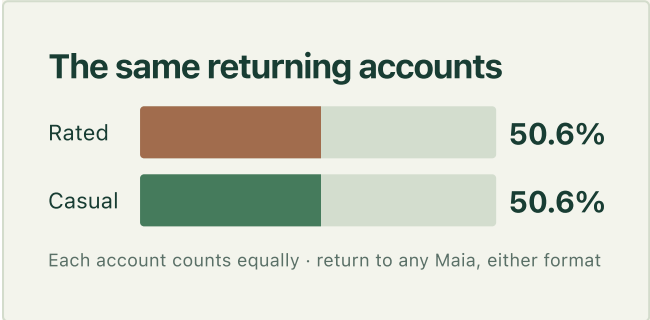
In both formats, roughly four in ten accounts appear just once. Yet just 1% of accounts contribute more than half the games. Casual play has the larger observed audience; neither format is evenly spread across its accounts.

Top 1% is chosen separately for each format, with the number of accounts rounded to the nearest whole account. Anonymous games stay in total-game denominators but cannot enter account counts.

Habit	Rated	Casual
Accounts observed	93,020	128,628
Exactly one observed game	45.2%	41.1%
Median games per account	2	2
Games from busiest 1% of accounts	57.7%	54.0%

Same regulars. Almost identical return rates.

Both formats have a **50.6% quick-return rate** when each qualifying account counts equally. We follow the next observed Maia game across **both** formats. To reduce the effect of different audiences, this comparison uses 2,982 accounts with at least ten eligible standard-start games in each format.



A quick return starts within ten minutes of the previous last recorded move. Each eligible prior game stays in the denominator, even if no later game is observed.

What follows a win or a loss?

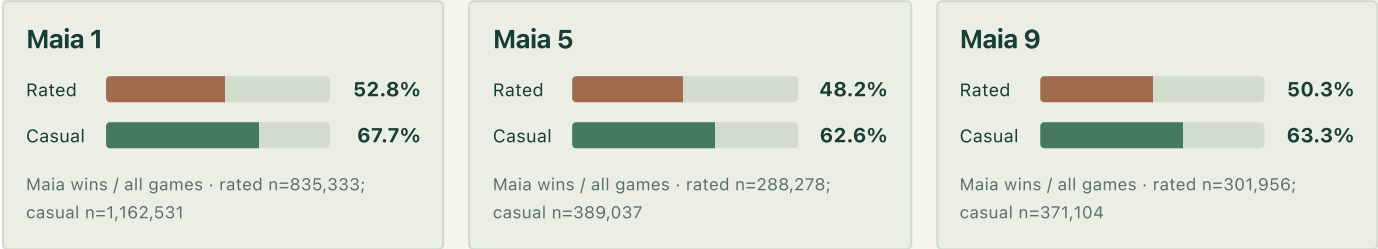
Previous game	Rated	Casual
Any outcome	50.6%	50.6%
Opponent won	39.3%	38.6%
Opponent lost	57.4%	56.2%

Opponent's result in the prior game. For each row, average each qualifying account's return rate equally; outcome-specific rows include only accounts with that outcome. This describes return behavior, not motivation.

Most quick returns stay in the same format. Across eligible standard-start games, 99.2% of quick returns after rated games are rated again; 99.1% after casual games are casual again. This uses all identified accounts, so it is a different population from the equal-account comparison above.

Separate the starting position. Then compare the opponents.

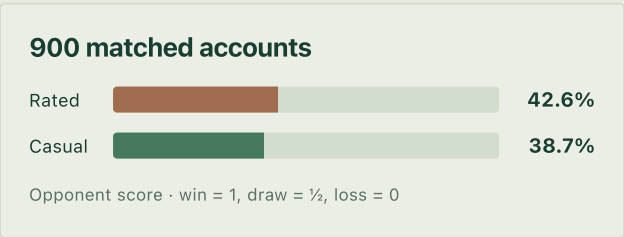
Raw casual and rated results mix different accounts, clocks and starting positions. Below, **standard-tagged games** are the default. Win percentages use **all games**, including draws and unknown outcomes, so they match the definition in the original report.



Maia	Format	Games	Maia wins	Draws	Maia loses	Unknown
Maia 1	Rated	835,333	52.8%	6.7%	40.3%	0.2%
Maia 1	Casual	1,162,531	67.7%	4.7%	27.4%	0.2%
Maia 5	Rated	288,278	48.2%	8.0%	43.6%	0.2%
Maia 5	Casual	389,037	62.6%	5.6%	31.7%	0.1%
Maia 9	Rated	301,956	50.3%	8.2%	41.2%	0.3%
Maia 9	Casual	371,104	63.3%	5.7%	30.8%	0.2%

Bot perspective. A white/black winner determines win or loss; a blank winner is a draw only for explicit draw/stalemate status, otherwise unknown. Full-collection tables retain recorded cheat terminations; the matched comparison below excludes them.

What if we compare the same accounts?



For each account, match the **same Maia, exact clock, speed category and color**, with at least ten known-outcome standard games in each format. Give each selected account equal weight.

Average opponent score is **3.9 percentage points lower in casual** in this selected group. This is an association, not the effect of turning rating points on or off.

One qualifying combination per account, selected by the largest smaller-format game count, then total games. Games need not be contemporaneous: the median absolute gap between the two formats' mean start dates is 40 days. Outside practice, changes over time, and format choice can still explain differences. This is not an early/late improvement study.

Both grew. Rated grew faster.

+79.4%

rated games

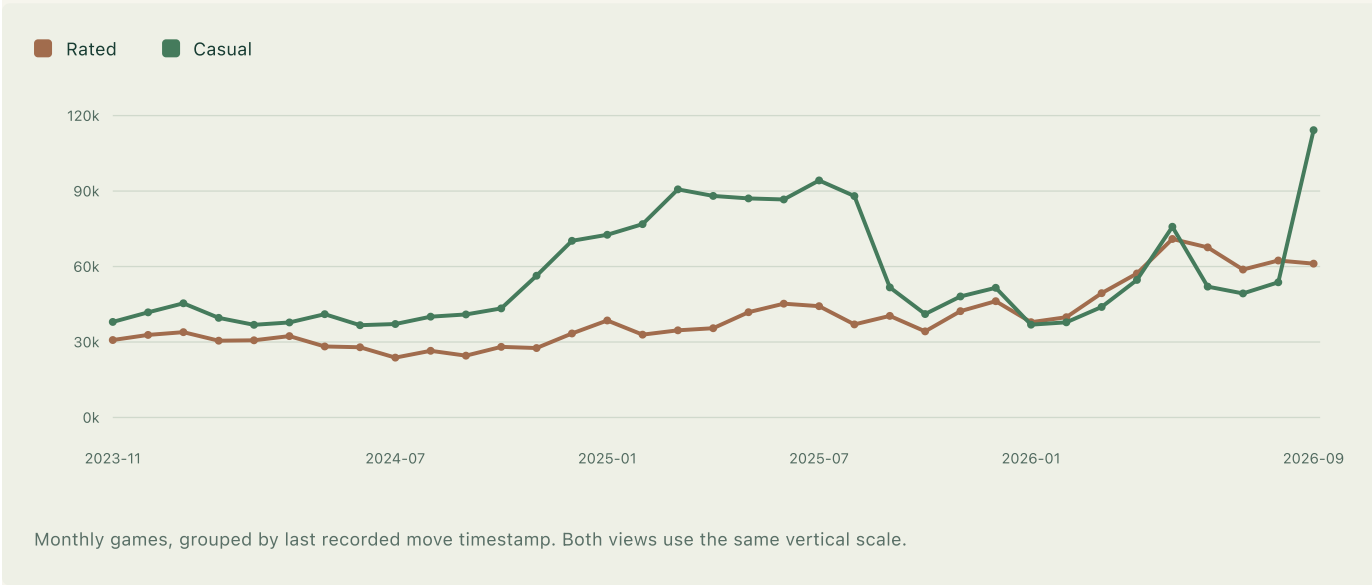
+37.7%

casual games

+24.4%

casual, excluding one account's September games

Earliest complete 12 months: Nov 2023–Oct 2024. Latest: Oct 2025–Sep 2026. This is not a comparison of consecutive years. Partial October 2023 and October 2026 are excluded. Across these blocks, casual's share of combined games falls from 57.8% to 51.2%.



One account, 63,504 September games. That is 55.6% of the month's casual volume. Excluding only those games leaves 50,729 casual September games, versus 53,754 in August. Meanwhile, casual active accounts went from 4,594 in August to 4,446 in September. The volume spike is not a surge in account numbers.

The sensitivity view retains that account's other months and all other games. It is a concentration check, not a claim about its identity, motives or legitimacy. We have not verified that every opposing account is human.

Shared habits. Different contexts.

Similarities

The same most-played Maia, the same top three clocks, many one-game visitors and a small core producing most of the games. Those patterns recur in both formats.

Differences

A larger casual audience, limited observed overlap, somewhat more slow chess, and different results—even within a selected matched group. The raw format averages alone do not explain why.

What remains unanswered

Whether one format improves chess skill more. These metadata contain no moves or evaluations, and the choice of format is not randomized. The original rated early/late analysis remains a separate question.

Check	Rated	Casual
Records	1,425,567	2,040,728
Standard variant tag	1,425,567	1,922,672
fromPosition variant tag	0	118,056
Missing account handles	147	2

Frozen observed exports: last recorded move at or after 4 Oct 2023 00:00 UTC and before 4 Oct 2026 09:00 UTC. All 3,466,295 IDs are unique across the published corpora. Verification covers hashes, sizes, rows, IDs and timestamps; public files cannot independently prove API completeness. Casual collection used a seven-day creation-time lookback; longer boundary-crossing games can still be missed. Recorded Lichess ratings mix speed-specific pools and are not a clean casual skill measure.

[Behavior & matched results · JSON ↗](#)[Comparison aggregates · JSON ↗](#)[Monthly data · CSV ↗](#)

[Casual records & field guide ↗](#)[Methods ↗](#)

Source: [Lichess user-game export](#). No moves, FENs, PGNs, chat, credentials or private identity mappings are included. Independent fan research, not an official Maia or Lichess publication. The MIT license covers original writing and code, not a relicensing of Lichess or player data.